



Statue of St. James as Matamoros, slayer of the Moors, in the Cathedral of Saint Mary, Burgos, Spain. (iStock/mahroch)

Even if I avoided the erasure of the religious violence in the Camino's history, my Camino program inadvertently perpetuated another form of exploitation involving the assertion of what I call "Protestant privilege"—claiming that Protestantism is the correct or normative expression of Christianity as well as assuming that all forms of religion should follow a Protestant model in form and structure. This form of exploitation was dramatically enacted during my 2016 program, which included four Evangelical students. These students were part of a campus religious organization, knew one another well, and thus were emboldened to express criticisms of Catholicism throughout the program. They were convinced that their interpretations of Christianity were the only right ones. The other students dubbed them the "God Squad." They didn't seem to mind.

The God Squad began their Camino journey hostile to the Catholic nature of the pilgrimage route. They were suspicious of relics. Distrustful of anything that had to do with Catholic institutions. Concerned about hierarchies that mediated their access to religious knowledge. To embrace the Camino as their own, the first step in any form of religious appropriation, they reconceptualized this journey as Protestant instead of Catholic. I noticed a couple of tactics they used: framing their participation on the Camino as a personal, unmediated experience; using it as a form of reconciliation of Catholicism and Protestantism; and trying to convert the nonreligious students in the program, effectively co-opting a study abroad program into an Evangelical missionary trip.

A particularly vivid example of this dynamic occurred on day six of the walk that year, the day we stopped in Portomarín for the night. As I mentioned earlier, something dramatic always happens on day six, when the group seems to hit an emotional wall. That year was no exception.

The topic of class discussion that day was sacraments in the Catholic Church, including how different the Catholic Eucharist is from what most Protestants call Communion. For both, this ritual commemorates the Last Supper of Jesus with his disciples before his crucifixion. It involves the eating of bread or a wafer and the drinking of wine. For Catholics, the wafer and wine, once consecrated by a priest, become the body and blood of Christ. This is called the doctrine of transubstantiation. In Protestant Communion, bread and wine are merely symbolic of Christ.

Protestants welcome the baptized to participate in Communion. In some Protestant churches, this means baptism in a particular tradition; for others, all Christian baptisms count. In the Catholic Church, however, you must believe in the doctrine of transubstantiation to participate in the Eucharist. It is also preferable that you have

been baptized in the Catholic Church and have been to confession so that you are in a “state of grace.” Putting it more simply, we can say that in most Protestant churches, Communion is allowable for all Christians, but in most Catholic churches, it is limited to Catholics in good standing. For instance, I was baptized as Catholic, but since I have never been to confession, and I don’t believe in transubstantiation, I have never taken Communion in a Catholic Mass.

During our class discussion about Catholic Eucharist, the God Squad, true to form, shared their opinion that Communion was the same for all Christians, and that it shouldn’t matter what church it took place in. I pushed back. “To you, it might be, but what would it mean to take the beliefs of your Catholic hosts seriously?” One of the God Squad, whom I’ll call Chris, raised his hand and said slowly, “For me, as a faithful Christian, my Camino has been about coming to peace with Catholicism. I now see how much in common all Christians have.” “That is great, Chris,” I said as patiently as I could, quite used to his attempt to shut down conversation by claiming expertise in all matters Christian based on his being a faithful Evangelical. “But I wonder how you might respond to the question I’m raising. If ‘Communion is for everyone’ is a Protestant idea, could asserting it here, on a Catholic pilgrimage, be a form of privilege?”

Chris shot a look to Abigail, another member of the God Squad. She shifted in her chair. There were a few moments of uncomfortable silence and then a quiet, red-headed Catholic student named Emily offered, “It is true that Communion is something pretty serious in the Catholic Church. I mean, my parents won’t even take it if they haven’t been to confession.” I saw another Catholic student nod his head. Emily went on, “It does seem different than how I am hearing some of you talk about it.”

I had thought naively that conversation went well, that we had raised some interesting, if uncomfortable, effects of taking the diversity

of Christianity seriously. I thought that Chris had begun to see that claiming to speak on behalf of all Christian faithful was a form of erasure. But I was wrong.

After class, a small group of us headed to evening Mass at the local church. The group included the God Squad, who attended every optional church service possible, two Catholic students, and me. Because it was a small church, we were able to sit as a group: the God Squad together and the two Catholic students and I directly behind them.

The moment for the Eucharist came. The God Squad stood up. I didn't think, just reacted, and bent forward into the pew in front of me and whispered very slowly, "Sit back down." They did, reluctantly.

For the rest of the Mass, I was really upset because I knew I had messed up. My reaction was inappropriate. Encouraging them to think critically about religious differences within Christianity was one thing. Preventing them from a religious ritual they thought they were entitled to was another. In my attempt to teach them to see Communion through a Catholic lens, I had overstepped, becoming a scolding parent who put them in time-out.

Even worse, my shushing showed I was a bit of a hypocrite. I was frustrated at the God Squad for trying to own Christianity, and yet I was policing its borders as well by insisting that a Catholic Communion was only for Catholics.

I stopped everyone as we were leaving the church and asked them to huddle up. I took a breath. "I apologize for stopping you. It is not my job to tell you how to be a good Christian." Another breath. "I am sorry." The God Squad seemed pleased. When we got back to the inn for dinner, I overheard Abigail tell her end of the table, "Liz really messed up at Mass just now," and then saw her grin smugly.

As I sit and write about that day, I can see that I had overreacted. Who would have known those students were planning to participate in the Eucharist to colonize Christianity? Not the priest, not the

other pilgrims. But I would have known. To me, the God Squad's attempt to take Communion felt especially disrespectful to the Catholic students sitting next to me, given that they knew these students would understand their actions as a transgression. But that was not enough to justify my whispered command.

Even if I had messed up that day, it was also a moment that helped me identify two additional forms of exploitation that occurred within my Camino program: decentering Catholics from the Christian experience and creating a crisis of faith.

Pilgrimage to Santiago started before the distinction between Catholic and Protestant existed. But given the critique of pilgrimage by leading Protestant Reformers, after the Reformation, the Camino lost most of its British, Dutch, and German Protestant pilgrims, while it remained an important destination for Catholics. Today, the Camino is institutionally maintained, supported, and promoted by the Catholic Church. A Catholic cathedral houses the remains of St. James. Catholic churches dot the route to Santiago. The Pilgrim Office, which issues Compostelas as certificates of completion, is run by the Metropolitan Archdiocese of Compostela.

Yet, despite the importance of Catholicism to this pilgrimage route, the God Squad made me aware of how Protestantism has become dominant in pilgrim culture. I saw up close how the God Squad domesticated the Camino's Christianity for their Protestant goals. Their reimagined Camino was no longer part of a penitentiary system but an experience of Protestant devotion. It was unmediated by the Catholic Church. They explicitly resisted any course material I introduced that was meant to highlight the diversity of global Christianity. Their experience of Camino did little more than reinforce their existing understanding of religion.

But the dominance of Protestantism was not something the God Squad introduced to the Camino; rather, it was a dynamic that we can

observe on many levels. Catholic Masses in towns we passed through were empty, whereas pilgrim Masses, intentionally developed to appeal to a wide range of Christian and non-Christian pilgrims, were packed. This created a context in which the God Squad felt justified to participate in the Eucharist. **The Catholicism of the pilgrimage has been diluted sometimes by the Catholic Church itself—such as granting Compostelas to non-Catholic and even non-Christian pilgrims—to make the experience universally accessible.**

There is one more lesson I learned from the God Squad that year: If part of the goal of experiential study abroad is for students to become self-critical about their own cultural values, programs that focus on religion can lead to a crisis of faith, and that would be a profoundly offensive result. This seems a particular risk when students enroll in a study abroad program that focuses on what they consider to be their own religious tradition.

The God Squad were all white Evangelicals. In the United States, they had grown up as part of the religious majority and had enjoyed a support system that affirmed their Christian practice, including an active Christian student group on Northeastern's campus. However, as Protestants in Spain, they were a religious minority and had been confronted for the first time with the possibility that they did not have exclusive ownership of Christianity. Given how much course time I spent on the role of Islam in Spanish history, they also faced unsettling narratives of violence and oppression carried out in the name of Christianity. The God Squad dealt with what they perceived as challenges to their faith by doubling down on their belief that their version of Christianity was not only correct but also universalizable.

I was at a bit of a loss of what to do when the God Squad shifted class discussion to topics of a more personal devotional nature. I was confident that I knew quite a bit about the interaction of multiple religious traditions in Spain, the power dynamics that have created the

modern Camino, and various forms of ethical thinking that can help us describe the pilgrim experience. But when it came to Christian faith, the God Squad were quite right: they were the experts. I did not have any insight to offer into a journey to become a better Christian.

This leads me to ask, **What is the proper role, if any, for a religious studies instructor in guiding personal religious experiences that can occur in study abroad programs?** I think the answer “none” is too glib. Like it or not, at least in intensive faculty-led study abroad programs like mine, instructors are often asked to take on the role of not only teacher but also mentor and even surrogate parent. When the topic of study is religion, some students will look to their instructor for religious guidance. My tactic has been to use scholarly readings to guide our class discussions of religion, and to encourage the working out of personal beliefs in informal group conversations that happen organically while we walk—in which, instead of me, their peers give advice and serve as sounding boards—or in daily journal entries. Sometimes Manuel steps into the role of religious guide. His personality, which I’d describe as Galician macho caveman meets poetic teddy bear, and his role as a judo coach, means he feels comfortable giving advice to young people about just about everything. He also identifies as Catholic and had spent a few years working in the Pilgrim Office of the Cathedral of Santiago, so he has his own devotional and work experience to draw on.

All my tactics to remain out of students’ personal religious journeys, however, failed the year of the God Squad. That failure was seen in my scolding them in the Portomarín Catholic chapel but also in how uncomfortable the God Squad made some students in the group. What I intended to foster was an environment where students could confront discomfort and sit in it, not feel attacked or judged by their peers or me. And certainly, I had not intended to create an environment that **encouraged a crisis of faith.** But my failure shows that the

stakes of study abroad programs that focus on religion can be quite different from those that concern other subject matters, and especially for students who identify with the religion they have signed up to have an immersive experience with.

Explicit theological reflection often occurs when a student engages in an experiential program that focuses on their own religion, independent of the instructor's intention.³³ As a religious studies professor, for instance, I am uncomfortable and frankly unqualified to guide personal theological learning for confessional insiders, and this is not the purpose of a liberal arts approach to religion. Put differently, I don't see my job as to assist with my student's religious formation—it is to provide context and analytical tools to understand and think critically about the role of religion in human life. And yet, to reiterate what has become a theme in this book, religion is not so easily controlled, especially in a real-world setting. Despite my intentions, I could not guarantee that the experience of the Camino for a Christian student would only be a case of humanistic learning.

Economic Inequality, Christian Hegemony, and the Hierarchy of Higher Education

My students hope that pilgrimage will be an experience in which they leave behind the expectations put on them in their normal life, so as to become the best version of themselves. The exploitations I enumerated tell a different story. As with other case studies in this book, existing structural injustices are not avoided during a pilgrimage; instead, they are illuminated and even intensified. In my Camino program, these include economic disparities, Christian hegemony, and a hierarchical theory of learning.

Medieval pilgrimage was meant to be a great equalizer. Kings and peasants walked the same path to Santiago in the hope of earning an